

years of age, he tells us that he “conceived the bold and arduous project of arriving at moral perfection. . . . I knew, or thought I knew, what was right and wrong, and I did not see why I might not *always* do the one or avoid the other.” The task, he tells us, was more difficult than he imagined, but he ultimately listed 13 virtues—including temperance, silence, order, frugality, industry, sincerity, and justice—even ranking them in order of importance. He began each day with “The Morning Question: What Good shall I do this day?” and ended with “The Evening Question: What Good have I done today?” It is hard to imagine a philosophy of self-improvement cast in a more ethical fashion.

Even viewed through the lens of twenty-first-century cynicism rather than eighteenth-century idealism, I confess a sense of wonder at the young Franklin’s moral strength and disciplined self-improvement. While few of us in today’s society would have the will to pursue a written agenda of virtue, Franklin had established, in his own words, the “character of Integrity” that would give him so much influence with his fellow citizens in the struggle for American independence.

That character was also central to his dedication to the public interest, so easily observable in his entrepreneurship, in the joy he took from his creations and from exercising his ingenuity, his energy, and his persistence. And that character also found its expression in Franklin’s ongoing struggle to balance pride with humility—a battle that in this age of bright lights, celebrity, and money we seem to have largely abandoned. As Franklin wrote in his autobiography:

In reality, there is, perhaps, no one of our natural passions so hard to subdue as pride. Disguise it, struggle with it, beat it down, stifle it, mortify it as much as one pleases, it is still alive, and will every now and then peep out and show itself; you will see it perhaps often in this history; for even if I could conceive that I had completely overcome it, I should probably be proud of my humility.